

and then returned to the island. Former residents recall their experiences living on the island as peaceful and with a strong community. Happy memories are reported by those who lived in a unique island environment.

Although Alcatraz was an effective prison, it was extremely costly to operate. By the early 1960s the salt water was causing significant deterioration of the structures that needed expensive renovations. Public opinion had changed since the building of the prison, and there was a national campaign to emphasize rehabilitation of prisoners. In 1963, Attorney General Robert Kennedy announced the closing of Alcatraz Federal Prison. At this time, the prison is a very popular tourist attraction. People can roam the island and tour the cell blocks.

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See also: [Attica](#); [Leavenworth](#); [Notorious or Infamous Inmates](#)

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American Prison Designs

The architectural structure of American penitentiaries has always been aligned with an ideological view about correctional facilities. In America, during the Enlightenment in the 18th century, there was a European-influenced shift from the deontological retributive ideology toward a more utilitarian view in the purpose of prisons. This new perspective included the notion that incarceration can be used as a means of deterrence, incapacitation, and rehabilitation. The use of prisons was not solely viewed as a means of punishment but more so as a way to keep the general public safe. The birth of New York's Auburn Prison and the later development of Pennsylvania's Eastern State Penitentiary are exemplary of this shift, and their architectural designs correspond with the utilitarian motive. By no surprise, the radial layouts of these two prisons were influenced by a utilitarian European scholar named Jeremy Bentham and his panopticon prison design.

Bentham introduced the idea of the correctional institution as a source of power and control over the individual through his panopticon prison design. At the center of his proposed construction was a guard post that had a view of all inmate cells. In addition, the center post was constructed in a fashion where inmates are unaware of when someone is supervising them from this fixture. Bentham's omniscient post enabled the prison guard to supervise all without being seen. The design's purpose was to create a panoptic effect where inmates abide by the institutional rules in fear of being caught breaking them. Arguably, the panoptic design contains the ideological belief of that time, that humans are rational actors. Thus, through the manipulation of facility design, an inmate's behavior could be manipulated.

The layouts of prisons in the United States can be categorized by five main designs: (1) the telephone pole design, (2) the radial design, (3) the courtyard design, (4) the campus-style design, and (5) the high-rise design.

The first is the telephone pole design. This layout is composed of one major corridor that is used for inmate and staff movement throughout the facility. From this central corridor are pathways or wings that protrude parallel to one another and that extend from both sides of the singular corridor. These wings lead to cell blocks and other locations in the correctional facility. The blueprint resembles the manner in which a human's ribs (cell blocks and facility wings) protrude from the sternum (the main corridor).

The second layout is the radial design. In this facility cells are arranged in a linear manner, and all cell blocks and facility wings meet at a central point in the prison. The design resembles the shape of a star or a wheel. At the central point of the facility are controls that open and close the gates to every wing—permitting or denying the access of inmates and personnel to other areas of the facility.

Another layout utilized is the campus-style design, which consists of several independent correctional buildings that are enclosed in a secure perimeter. The standalone buildings are placed at a distance from one another and include various facilities such as housing units, medical services, and more.

The courtyard design encompasses a mixture of both the telephone and campus-style design. Buildings are placed in a manner in which they form a square or rectangular shape. Inmate sleeping quarters and other correctional facility amenities are located inside these structures. Located outside the facility buildings in the center of the square is a shared courtyard.

In the high-rise prison design the layout builds upward in a style resembling inner-city apartment buildings or skyscrapers. The multilayered facility utilizes the individual floors of a facility to separate offenders and dedicate specific landings for certain purposes such as vocational training or administrative offices.

Prison designs allow for the separation or the classification of specific groups of inmates. Separation of individuals are commonly done on the basis of age, gender, and offense. These classifications have observable impacts on the design of a correctional facility. The security levels in federal prisons can be identified by the construction of minimum, low, medium, high, and administrative facilities. For state-controlled prisons, the security levels vary in terms, but definitions follow a similar pattern of low to high level. The placement in one security level over another is based on administrative discretion, the capacity that a facility has, the type of offense convicted of, prior criminal convictions, gang affiliations, other individual level characteristics that may foster security risks, and facility level characteristics that can control those risks.

Federal minimum security facilities have limited or no fencing, lower number of staff per inmate, dormitory housing, and some work and programs for the inmates. Low security level facilities have an increase in staff-to-inmate ratio, doubled fenced perimeters, more work and programs for inmates, and dormitory-style housing. The medium security facility includes stronger enforced perimeters, such as electronic gates, cell-type housing, and an increase in work and treatment programs for inmates. High security level penitentiaries, sometimes referred to as maximum on the state level, are characterized by multiple- and single-cell housing, increased levels in staff-to-inmate ratio, further strengthened perimeters, and a high level of control over inmate movement. In some maximum security facilities, inmates are kept confined in their cells for 23 hours a day, limiting any time spent outside the cell. Administrative facilities are a mixture of institutions designed for different types of offenders, such as inmates with chronic medical issues. Included in administrative facilities are super maximum (supermax) prisons that are built for highly violent and escape-prone inmates.

The structure of the prison begins with the entrance. These facilities are usually encased in exterior barriers such as barbed fencing, natural barriers (e.g., water), or walls in order to maintain security. In addition, one may find correctional officer posts surrounding the perimeter and at various checkpoints throughout the facility. These checkpoints serve the function of identifying and searching all individuals seeking to enter a given facility. Once cleared, individuals may be directed to enter the prison through a sally port, which is a fortified entry. Individuals are likely to encounter more identification and search posts further along entering a prison.

The housing unit is a structure in the prison where the cell blocks and cells can be found. Housing units are strategically classified by offender risk level. This includes classification by inmates on mental health surveillance, inmates who are in protective custody units, inmates with proven histories of good behavior, or any other classification created. The cell block within a housing unit refers to a row of cells, and the cell refers to the sleeping quarters of an inmate. Moreover, the cell may be sealed off by a steel door and include a toilet and a sink inside. Sleeping quarters are found in three main forms: single cells, double cells (e.g., two-person rooms), and dormitories (e.g., multiple beds in an open room). For some facilities one may find a dayroom within the housing unit as well. The dayroom refers to a structure that allows inmates from that specific unit to congregate outside of their cells. The dayroom will include seats and may have a television present as well.

Another structure present in the prison is the control room, which allows officers to log information and monitor inmates from a separate room. This is usually located near the entrance of the housing unit with a physical view and electronic view (e.g., CCTV) of the cell blocks. In addition, the control room allows for not only the surveillance of offenders, but for the opening and closing of cells and the entrance to the housing unit.

There is one last structure used to house inmates: punitive segregation. In some prisons this is also known as the “shoe,” “the box,” “the bing,” or solitary confinement. In these structures, individuals are housed separately with no interaction with other inmates, and depending on the security level, no face-to-face interaction with correctional officers. Inmates may be sent there for various reasons with the most common being violent behavior.

Visitation rooms are utilized in prisons as the location for inmates to meet and spend time with outside visitors. Visitors may include family, friends, lawyers, journalists, researchers, and other approved guests. The visitation room may be set up with seating in an open space that includes many inmates and their families, or it may take place in a private room. A private room may be necessary for inmates who may be restricted from any interaction with other inmates.

Other structures usually found in prisons include gymnasiums for recreational use, chapels for religious services, educational or vocational classrooms, libraries, laundry rooms, cafeterias, kitchens, and administrative offices.

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See also: [Alcatraz](#); [Angola](#); [Attica](#); [Custody Levels](#); [Environmentally Friendly \(“Green”\) Prisons](#); [Florence ADX](#); [Inmate Classification](#); [Jails Compared to Prisons](#); [Juvenile Detention Centers](#); [Leavenworth](#); [Maximum Security](#); [Panopticon](#); [Prisons, History of](#); [San Quentin](#); [Solitary Confinement](#); [Visitation](#)

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Angola

The term “Angola” is a nickname under which the Louisiana State Penitentiary is known because countless slaves in the United States of America came from Angola in Africa. Angola, also known as “The Farm,” is the largest maximum security prison in the United States. Given that the prison is the only maximum security facility in Louisiana, it houses inmates convicted of the most serious and violent crimes. Hence, the majority of inmates in Angola have a life sentence, and the facility is also the location of the execution chamber for death row inmates. Although only the condemned men are housed in Angola, the prison carries out executions for both male and female inmates who have been sentenced to death. Due to the high number of aging inmates who will never be released, a hospice program was introduced in the prison in 1998. Two years after the launch of the program, Angola Hospice Chapel was established, which allowed for the inmates to have formal funerals on the prison grounds. In relation to general medical care, a medical center for various inpatient services is available; nonetheless, the inmates with serious medical issues or those who are in need of surgery must be transferred elsewhere. Apart from medical services, a variety of educational and rehabilitative programs are offered at Angola. For example, inmates may learn a trade such as eyeglass repair or participate in a prerelease exit program.

Angola is best known because of its presence in the media mainly due to its penal tourism activities and activism. Since 2001, Louisiana State Penitentiary hosts an Arts and Crafts Festival where inmates with a good record can present and sell the goods that they have created through obtaining craft materials